This classic French soup takes time to make, but is well worth waiting for. Try serving this with coarse-grained mustard, gherkins, and creamed horseradish.

pot au feu

SERVES 4 **PREP** 40 MINS **COOK** 2 HRS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

a few beef bones, if possible
2¼lb (1 kg) braising steak cut into 2–2½in (5–6cm) pieces
salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 large carrot, thickly cut on the diagonal
2 turnips, thickly sliced
1 medium-to-large waxy potato, cut into 8 pieces
1 Spanish onion, halved
2 garlic cloves, crushed
3 cloves
1 large leek, thickly sliced
3 celery ribs, chopped
3 bay leaves
several sprigs each of thyme and parsley

1 Put any bones in a large, deep, heavy pan. Place the meat on top of the bones. Cover with plenty of cold water, at least 2½in (6cm) above the meat, and very slowly bring to a simmer over low heat. Season lightly with salt and pepper. Skim off any foam that rises to the surface. Cover and let simmer very gently for 1 hour, while you prepare the vegetables. Cut one half of the onion into slices and press the cloves into the other half.

2 Skim the meat again. Add the prepared vegetables to the pan, with the bay leaves, thyme, and parsley. Bring back to a simmer and skim again. Season lightly. Reduce the heat, partially cover, and cook gently for at least 45 minutes, until the meat and vegetables are tender.

3 Skim again if necessary, then lift out the meat and vegetables and put in a large shallow bowl or in individual bowls. Discard the bones, the onion stuck with cloves, bay leaves, thyme, and parsley.

4 Strain the stock into a saucepan through a muslin-lined sieve. Bring to a simmer and season if required. Ladle sufficient stock over the meat and vegetables. Let the remaining stock cool. There should be plenty left for you to use in other dishes (keep refrigerated for up to 3 days, or freeze).